

Wednesday, 20 May 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON

Light drizzle

20° 13°

BIRMINGHAM

Drizzle

18° 11°

MANCHESTER

Light drizzle

16° 11°

GLASGOW

Light drizzle

15° 11°

01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

1

UK unemployment rate unexpectedly rises.

The number of UK job vacancies also fell to its lowest level in five years as the initial impact of the Iran war on businesses starts to be seen.

UK · NEWS

2

BBC confirms new Strictly Come Dancing hosts.

The trio replace Tess Daly and Claudia Winkleman, who left the BBC dance competition last year.

UK · NEWS

3

Supermarkets urged to limit food prices by government.

Any price caps would be voluntary apply to key groceries such as eggs, bread, and milk, the BBC understands.

UK · NEWS

02 – SHOWBIZ

What's coming up

1

BBC confirms new Strictly Come Dancing hosts.

The trio replace Tess Daly and Claudia Winkleman, who left the BBC dance competition last year.

SHOWBIZ · UK

2

Bangaranga! Bulgaria wins Eurovision - but UK comes last.

Bulgarian singer Dara is a surprise winner beating Israel in second place, while the UK's Look Mum No Computer gets just one point.

SHOWBIZ · UK

3

'Look Mum, one point': Why does the UK keep getting Eurovision wrong?.

After four years of flops, the BBC has to think hard about how it approaches Eurovision in 2027.

SHOWBIZ · UK

On the schedule

1

Did England 'fake relationships' cost team 2006 World Cup glory?.

Former England players and coaching staff reflect on whether intense Premier League rivalries may have undermined the so-called Golden Generation at the 2006 World Cup.

SPORT · UK

2

Usyk v Verhoeven - all you need to know.

Everything you need to know about Oleksandr Usyk's world title defence against Rico Verhoeven in Egypt on Saturday.

SPORT · UK

3

He's changed the face of English football - Rooney on Guardiola.

Wayne Rooney, Kelly Somers and Kae Kurd discuss the influence Pep Guardiola has had on English football and consider the impact his expected departure from Manchester City will have on the Premier League.

SPORT · UK

4

'I broke the curse' - the fall and rise of a teenage Grand Slam champion.

When 19-year-old Bianca Andreescu stunned Serena Williams to win the US Open. It was unthinkable it would be more than 2,300 days before her next triumph.

SPORT · UK

Quick hits

- 1 Brits spend an average of 38 minutes a day deciding what to watch — and 12 of those are spent scrolling Netflix.**
'Watch-paralysis' has its own subreddit. Streamers are quietly experimenting with 'shuffle' buttons that just play something.
- 2 More than half of UK workers would take a 10% pay cut to never go into the office again — but only 17% of bosses say they'd offer one.**
The gap is growing again after forced return-to-office rules. HR experts say the tension shows up in resignation rates, particularly for under-35s.
- 3 Loneliness is now considered a bigger health risk than smoking 15 cigarettes a day, according to NHS England.**
Social prescribing — GPs referring patients to community activities — is rolling out nationwide. Walking groups, book clubs and choirs are reportedly oversubscribed.
- 4 The most-Googleed DIY question in Britain this year: 'how to remove silicone'.**
Tradespeople say it's the rise of botched bathroom resealing jobs during lockdown that's still haunting people. YouTube tutorials on the topic have racked up 60 million views.
- 5 British baby names are getting shorter again — three- and four-letter names are dominating the registrar.**
Top picks this year: Noa, Ezra, Ada and Bo. Long, multi-syllable Victorian names like Theodora are sliding back down the chart.
- 6 Holiday firms report a 40% spike in 'shoulder season' bookings — September and October sun trips are way up on last year.**
Travellers blame school-holiday flight prices, unreliable summer weather, and 'August feels too crowded these days'. Spain, Greece and Portugal top the wish list.
- 7 Roses are out, peonies are in — UK florists report a 200% rise in peony orders for weddings this summer.**
Brides cite 'softer, less staged' aesthetics. Wholesale peony prices have crept up accordingly.

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q 44% of us have done **THIS** while waiting for a kettle to boil. What?
ANSWER: WANDERED OFF AND FORGOTTEN ABOUT IT ENTIRELY.

Q 75% of us check **THIS** more than ten times a day. What?
ANSWER: THE WEATHER APP.

TALK TOPIC

- **If you won the lottery tonight, what's the FIRST thing you'd buy tomorrow?**
Talk-back: not the dream house. Not the holiday. The first daft thing you'd buy because you finally could.
- **What's the worst job you've ever had — and how long did you last?**
Talk-back: the war stories are usually the funniest. Bonus marks for under a fortnight.

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **Tech.** A start-up has invented a wearable that gently vibrates to remind you to drink water — and reportedly raised £3 million in two days on Kickstarter.

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** Researchers at Manchester University have built an AI that can predict which biscuit you'll dunk in your tea next, based only on the way you hold the mug.

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£25 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£3.8 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- A blue whale's tongue alone weighs as much as an elephant.
- Octopuses can taste with their suckers.
- Wales has more castles per square mile than any other country in the world.
- Bananas grow upside down.
- Your nose can detect over a trillion different scents.
- The unicorn is the national animal of Scotland.
- There are more trees on Earth than stars in the Milky Way.
- A snail can sleep for three years at a time.

On this day

Day 140 of the year, 225 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Abercius and Helena; Christian feast day: Alcuin of York; Christian feast day: Aurea of Ostia; Christian feast day: Austregisilus. Star sign Taurus, birthstone Emerald.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1946 — Cher, American singer-songwriter, producer, and actress
- 1944 — Keith Fletcher, English cricketer and manager
- 1970 — Louis Theroux, Singaporean-English journalist and producer
- 1972 — Busta Rhymes, American rapper, producer, and actor
- 1944 — Joe Cocker, English singer-songwriter (died 2014)
- 1961 — Clive Allen, English international footballer and manager
- 1940 — Shorty Long, American singer-songwriter and producer (died 1969)
- 1949 — Michèle Roberts, English author and poet

THE DAY TODAY

- 1980 — In a referendum in Quebec, the population rejects, with 60% of the vote, a government proposal to move towards independence from Canada.
- 1948 — Generalissimo Chiang Kai-shek wins the 1948 Republic of China presidential election and is sworn in as the first President of the Republic of China at Nanjing.
- 1983 — First publications of the discovery of the HIV virus that causes AIDS in the journal Science by a team of French scientists including Françoise Barré-Sinoussi, Jean-Claude Chermann, and Luc Montagnier.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 1956 — In Operation Redwing, the first United States airborne hydrogen bomb is dropped over Bikini Atoll in the Pacific Ocean.
- 1985 — Radio Martí, part of the Voice of America service, begins broadcasting to Cuba.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 1989 — The Chinese authorities declare martial law in the face of pro-democracy demonstrations, setting the scene for the Tiananmen Square massacre.
-

1965 — One hundred twenty-one people are killed when Pakistan International Airlines Flight 705 crashes at Cairo International Airport.

- 1969 — The Battle of Hamburger Hill in Vietnam ends.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 141 of the year, 224 days left in 2026. Today Afro-Colombian Day (Colombia); Christian feast day: Blessed Adílio Daronch and Manuel Gómez González; Christian feast day: Blessed Franz Jägerstätter; Christian feast day: Earliest day on which Corpus Christi can fall, while June 24 is the latest; held on Thursday after Trinity Sunday (often locally moved to Sunday). (Roman Catholic Church). Star sign Taurus, birthstone Emerald.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1949 — Andrew Neil, Scottish journalist and academic
- 1957 — Judge Reinhold, American actor and producer
- 1969 — Brian Statham, Rhodesian born English footballer and manager
- 1963 — Patrick Grant, American musician and producer
- 1941 — Martin Carthy, English singer-songwriter, guitarist, and producer
- 1974 — Fairuza Balk, American actress
- 1964 — Danny Bailey, English footballer and coach
- 1948 — Jonathan Hyde, Australian-English actor

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 2006 — The Republic of Montenegro holds a referendum proposing independence from the State Union of Serbia and Montenegro; 55% of Montenegrins vote for independence.
- 1982 — Falklands War: A British amphibious assault during Operation Sutton leads to the Battle of San Carlos.
- 1994 — The Democratic Republic of Yemen unsuccessfully attempts to secede from the Republic of Yemen; a war breaks out.

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 1981 — The Italian government releases the membership list of Propaganda Due, an illegal pseudo-Masonic lodge that was implicated in numerous Italian crimes and mysteries.
- 1998 — President Suharto of Indonesia resigns following the killing of students from Trisakti University earlier that week by security forces and growing mass protests in Jakarta against his ongoing corrupt rule.

Coming to cinemas

MAY 2026	
FRI 15	Mortal Kombat II (+ IMAX); Is God Is; Poetic License
FRI 22	The Mandalorian and Grogu (+ IMAX)
JUNE 2026	
FRI 5	Masters of the Universe; Power Ballad
FRI 12	Scary Movie 6; new Spielberg film (+ IMAX)
FRI 19	Pixar's Toy Story 5
FRI 26	Supergirl: Woman of Tomorrow (+ IMAX); A Private Life
JULY 2026	
WED 1	Minions & Monsters
FRI 3	Shiver; Young Washington
FRI 10	Moana (live action); Evil Dead Burn
FRI 17	Christopher Nolan's The Odyssey (+ IMAX); Cut Off
FRI 24	Heads of State; Untitled DCU
FRI 31	Spider-Man: Brand New Day

AUGUST 2026	
FRI 7	Once Upon a Time in a Cinema
FRI 14	Flowervale Street; PAW Patrol 3: The Dino Movie
FRI 21	Mutiny; The Bride!
FRI 28	Crime 101; Outcome
SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 4	Conjuring: Last Rites
FRI 11	Resident Evil reboot
FRI 18	The Black Phone 2
FRI 25	Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)
OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW	
FRI 16	Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller
FRI 23	Frankenstein (del Toro)

On the sporting calendar

MAY 2026		JULY 2026	
THU 14	PGA Championship begins (Golf)	4–26 JUL	Tour de France (Cycling)
WED 20	UEFA Europa League Final	SUN 5	British Grand Prix, Silverstone
SAT 23	EFL Championship Play-off Final, Wembley	16–19 JUL	The Open Championship (Golf)
SUN 24	Premier League final day (all 10 games, 3pm BST)	18–26 JUL	World Matchplay Darts, Blackpool
24 MAY – 7 JUN	French Open (Tennis)	23 JUL – 2 AUG	Commonwealth Games, Glasgow
THU 28	Premier League Darts Finals Night	AUGUST 2026	
SAT 30	UEFA Champions League Final	W/C 10	Hundred & T20 Blast climax (Cricket)
JUNE 2026		SAT 15	Premier League season begins (2026/27)
THU 4	NBA Finals begin	22–23	Belgian Grand Prix (F1)
11 JUN – 19 JUL	FIFA World Cup (USA / Canada / Mexico)		
11–14 JUN	World Cup of Darts		
12 JUN – 5 JUL	ICC Women's T20 World Cup (England & Wales)		
18–21 JUN	U.S. Open (Golf)		
29 JUN – 12 JUL	Wimbledon		